

A Case Study of Korea's Soft Power of K-Democracy in German-Speaking Countries (working title)

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K-민주주의,
미래를 향해 앞으
K-Democracy: Toward a New



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Research Background

- **Korea globally well known for its popular culture (K-drama, K-pop etc.) (Kim, 2022)**
 - Global popularity of Korean Wave → high soft power
 - Soft power: ability to shape the preferences of others (Nye, 2004)
 1. Cultural appeal
 2. Political values
 3. Foreign policies

Research Background

- **Primary focus of Korea's soft power used to be Korean popular culture (Kim, 2022, Jin, 2023)**
 - Expansion to K-democracy after candlelight protests and the incident of early December 2024 (Kim, 2025, July 14)
 - Emphasis on high resilience and desirable politic values (Choi 2025)

Research Background

- **Notion of K-democracy VS democratic backsliding**
 - Democratic backsliding: gradual erosion and discontinuity of fundamental characteristics of democracy (Waldner & Lust 2018)
 - In Korean context: populism, technocracy, far-right forces
- **In light of this contradiction:**
 - How do German-speaking newspapers frame the 12.3 incident and its protests and how do they interpret K-democracy?

Literature Review

- **Overview of the History of Korea's Democratic Development**
 - Ongoing debate about Korea's degree of consolidated democracy (Chang, 2022, 2025a, 2025b; Diamond & Kim, 2000)
 - Different definitions: minimalist democracy VS maximalist democracy (Diamond & Kim, 2000; Lee, 2007)

Literature Review

- **Overview of the History of Korea's Democratic Development**
 - Korean politics has yet to find a way to meaningfully and systematically represent its people (Chang 2025a)
 - Politics of Yoon Suk-Yeol government combined populism, technocracy, and far-right ideology → democratic backsliding (Cho, 2023; Park, 2025)

Literature Review

- **Korea's Soft Power: From Korean Popular Content to K-Democracy**
 - Korean government's policies essential part for global success of the Korean Wave (Jin, 2023; Kim, 2022)
 - Since mid-2000s all Korean governments have emphasised Hallyu as cultural diplomacy (Jin, 2023)
 - For example: Moon Jae-In occasionally invited BTS to high-level state visits (Jin, 2023)

Literature Review

- **Korea's Soft Power: From Korean Popular Content to K-Democracy**
 - In the case of Europe: Analysis of public perception of Korea by surveying Korean Studies experts (dimensions included: politics, contemporary culture, and history etc.) (Cho et al., 2023)
 - Germany and Austria show negative perception on Korea's politics
 - Korean Studies scholars → ordinary people?

Literature Review

- **Korea's Soft Power: From Korean Popular Content to K-Democracy**
 - After the 12·3 incident Lee Jae-Myung government started using the term K-democracy (Jeong, 2025, October 25, Kim, 2025, July 14)
 - (supposedely) high resilience of Korea's democracy → civilian protests
 - Beacon of hope and exemplary status for global arena

Literature Review

- **Media Framing of the 12·3 incident and its aftermath in English-speaking**

Newspapers

- Entman (1993): framing involves selecting certain aspects of perceived reality and highlighting them in a text in order to promote a specific problem definition, casual interpretation, moral evaluation or recommendation
- Domestication of English-speaking news reports revolving around the 12·3 incident (Ha, 2025)
 - For example U.S. newspapers warned against abuse of power inside the U.S., turning the Korean protests into a model for their own country

Research Purpose

- Examination of how German-speaking newspaper articles frame the 12·3 incident and its protests and how their interpretation of K-democracy is influenced by the popularity of the Korean Wave

RQ1: *How do German-speaking newspaper articles frame the 12·3 incident and its protests?*

RQ2: *How is this framing influenced by the notion of K-democracy and the popularity of the Korean Wave?*

Method

- **Qualitative framing analysis of German-speaking newspapers**
 - Austrian, German and Swiss newspapers that reported on the 12·3 incident, its aftermath and its protests
 - Time frame: early December 2023 ~ impeachment of former president Yoon Suk-Yeol

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